

Students using AI: are you concerned about the environmental impact?

Posted by u/Cloughiepig • 0 points • 135 comments

I have worked in unis for years now (non-teaching staff) and in the last 10 years or so, there have been loads of students and SUs doing projects to promote sustainability and preservation of the planet.

If you are a student using AI, do you think about it at all? It's a non-academic example, but I read recently that the "make me into a doll" generator uses as much electricity as an eight hour phone charge in just a few seconds.

Comments

u/dude_____ • 1 points • 2025-05-19 21:33 UTC

Extremely

u/Present-Cabinet-6653 • 2 points • 2025-05-19 14:51 UTC

They'll reply in a bit after asking ChatGPT.

u/Lanky-Permission969 • 2 points • 2025-05-19 11:59 UTC

I have recycled my whole life, limited plastic, car use and plane use when possible, I help in local environmental initiatives. All of this is undone every time a private jet is used for a short journey. My chat GPT use doesn't make a difference. Besides these AI companies will have to make changes to become self sufficient ie having their own energy sources for example solar. When it comes to the water if they are using actual water. That water can be filtered from sewage but if they are using mineral oil that's a whole different ball park. I'd personally use mineral oil as if there's a leak it's less likely to cause damage. There are also ways of recycling the old parts but again that's assuming the company's future proofing itself and plans on being self reliant. I feel like the investigations into this arnt deep enough and people just don't want change. Cars are a great example we saw worth and adapted and are adapting them to fit our needs. For example adding lights for people to cross the roads to stop people getting hit. Fossil fuel bad make electric cars lithium batters bad make gas powered cars. There are stages to this both in society and life of the product.

u/Mecury-BS • 2 points • 2025-05-19 11:15 UTC

Nope

u/classyclueless • 2 points • 2025-05-19 09:15 UTC

Whose fault is that? I'm not sure the blame should lie with a student.

u/ThatNegro98 • 1 points • 2025-05-19 10:38 UTC

Well imo, both the creator and the user are responsible. Ai isn't a necessity or anything. A lot of people don't **need** to use it at all.

If you are preaching sustainability, and you use ai knowing the environmental impact your query has... well, that's a great example of cognitive dissonance. "But it's helpful to me, so I don't care about this (even though it directly goes against my own values)"

>Whose fault is that?

I mean, businesses don't usually invest much money into things consumers don't want. Supply and demand init. That's oversimplifying things... but yeh. People use ai for stupid shit.

Now I'd say it's the companies job to inform people of the negatives of their product, so you can blame them for that and people not knowing.

u/Independent_Bed_7193 • 2 points • 2025-05-19 08:43 UTC

Oh yes, I'm going to jeopardise my career by giving myself a severe disadvantage just because I want to save a bit of electricity

u/Cloughiepig • 2 points • 2025-05-19 12:54 UTC

Depends upon your subject, but using/not using AI is unlikely to jeopardise your career

u/Independent_Bed_7193 • 1 points • 2025-05-20 15:46 UTC

It was an exaggeration! Still, AI can help with academics in many ways.

u/ComatoseSnake • 2 points • 2025-05-19 06:49 UTC

Are you concerned by the environment when you play a video game? Because the uses more energy.

u/Cloughiepig • 1 points • 2025-05-19 07:28 UTC

Personally I don't play games (because I am an old duffer who never got into that kind of thing), but I guess there is an interesting question from that:

Does anyone offset one activity for another?

I am driving a lot at the moment due to a sick relative 300 miles away. Could I cut back on something else to counteract the pollution that creates?